huge occasions in my mind; these were precious opportunities to make him proud.

It is a perfect, sunny winter's afternoon in 1996 and I have been picked to play flyhalf for the Warmbaths Primary School 1st XV, selected to play among the older boys 'a year up'. I have previously played at scrumhalf and at centre, but this is the first time I have been given a chance in my favoured position, at No. 10.

We are playing Krugerpark Primary School – traditionally strong opponents from Potgietersrus and, in my time at least, the one school we never seemed able to beat – on our main field. The score is level at 5–5 and, with seconds left, we win a scrum on the Krugerpark 10-metre line. I glance across at the crowd of parents on the touchline and instantly spot my father, standing there in his gleaming white GP's suit, watching intently.

This is my moment. The ball comes back from the scrum. I steady myself and, playing barefoot, try to kick a 40-metre drop goal to win the game. The connection is good and the ball passes, if not quite soars, between the posts.

We win.

Amid all the celebrations and back-slapping excitement that followed, I heard only one voice.

'Well done, son.'

This memory is as crystal clear as if the match was played yesterday.

My father's family lived in Vryburg, where my grandfather – Oupa Jan, as we called him – was headmaster of Stellaland Primary. My grandmother passed away when my father was a teenager, but I saw Oupa Jan every time I went to play in a tennis tournament in Vryburg.

He had played fullback for Boland in his youth and, perhaps bearing in mind the pressures of competitive sport, he used to hide behind a bush